

Technologies for Building Power in an Age of Democratic Backsliding: Advancing a Vision for People Power in CSCW Research

Kristine J. Lu
Northeastern University
Boston, Massachusetts, USA
k.lu@northeastern.edu

Matthew Easterday
School of Education & Social Policy
Northwestern University
Evanston, Illinois, USA
easterday@northwestern.edu

Gustavo Kreia Umbelino
Centre for Democracy Studies Aarau
University of Zurich
Aarau, Switzerland
gustavo.kreiaumbelino@zda.uzh.ch

Morgan Wu
School of Education & Social Policy
Northwestern University
Evanston, Illinois, USA
cwmorgan@u.northwestern.edu

Abstract

As the world faces new threats of authoritarianism, CSCW researchers must reckon with the dangerous consequences and new possibilities for technology to facilitate people-powered social change. Community organizing, where groups take collective action, develop leaders, and build power, has long been studied and practiced as one of the most impactful ways for ordinary people to contest for power on unequal political terrain. While existing civic technologies have explored collective actions from mass participation and mobilization, connective action, and democratic deliberation, CSCW researchers have focused less on examining the role of technologies in facilitating the complex work behind community organizing—from building the skills and capacities for organizations with powerful and resilient member bases, to supporting the relational work of transforming relationships into power. We invite researchers from across CSCW who are committed to social justice and democratic change to forge a research agenda for collaborative technologies that empower communities, particularly those most disenfranchised, to meet our global political moment. This SIG is designed to build relationships, establish a community of practice, and identify points of future research and collaboration—a crucial first step to realizing a transformative vision for CSCW research as civic and democratic duty in increasingly undemocratic times.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing** → Human computer interaction (HCI); HCI theory, concepts and models; Collaborative and social computing; Collaborative and social computing theory, concepts and paradigms; Computer supported cooperative work.

Permission to make digital or hard copies of all or part of this work for personal or classroom use is granted without fee provided that copies are not made or distributed for profit or commercial advantage and that copies bear this notice and the full citation on the first page. Copyrights for third-party components of this work must be honored. For all other uses, contact the owner/author(s).
CSCW Companion '25, Bergen, Norway
© 2025 Copyright held by the owner/author(s).
ACM ISBN 979-8-4007-1480-1/2025/10
<https://doi.org/10.1145/3715070.3748277>

Keywords

Community Organizing, Organizing Technologies, Power-Building

ACM Reference Format:

Kristine J. Lu, Gustavo Kreia Umbelino, Matthew Easterday, and Morgan Wu. 2025. Technologies for Building Power in an Age of Democratic Backsliding: Advancing a Vision for People Power in CSCW Research. In *Companion of the Computer-Supported Cooperative Work and Social Computing (CSCW Companion '25)*, October 18–22, 2025, Bergen, Norway. ACM, New York, NY, USA, 4 pages. <https://doi.org/10.1145/3715070.3748277>

1 Overview

As the world faces new threats of authoritarianism, mis- and disinformation, and democratic backsliding, CSCW researchers are confronted with new, urgent questions about a new political reality in which levers of power for social and structural change feel increasingly out of reach. To confront the changing geopolitical challenges for democracy around the world, this SIG is a call for CSCW research that boldly and creatively reconsiders the roles, goals, and possibilities—as well as limitations—for sociotechnical systems in civic life.

CSCW research has a long history of innovation focused on technologies for strengthening democratic life. From civic technologies for improving democratic deliberation and decision making [1, 20] to technologies for mobilizing turnout [23], community-based decision-making [8] or participatory budgeting technologies [14, 19] to technology for labor and grassroots organizing [4, 9], the past decade has seen a wide and sustained interest in CSCW researchers experimenting with different ways technology can improve civic life and collective action. CSCW workshops and SIGs of recent years have similarly offered important, generative spaces for pushing the boundaries of civic technology, including in the organizing and community-engaged research realms [7, 12, 21].

Yet democracies around the world are facing new and mounting threats. The past year alone has seen an unanticipated rapid rise in far-right parties around the world, culminating in the re-election of President Trump in the United States and its global aftershocks [18]. The latter has sparked a renewed flurry of protests, lawsuits, and other acts of political nonviolence and civil resistance across many

sectors of the American economy [11]. Meanwhile, technology and the role of social technologies, especially social media but not limited to, have become the subject of renewed scrutiny and questioning for their role in democratic backsliding—from mis- and disinformation [17], to extreme political polarization [16], to irresponsible or political conduct by corporate owners of major technology platforms [26].

There has hardly been a more urgent time for CSCW researchers to drive a conversation about a renewed vision of the role of social computing technologies in a people-centered vision of democracy. As an offering for starting this conversation, we bring tools and frameworks from research from social movements, community organizing, and open democracy to investigate the question: *How might CSCW build a transformative vision for social computing research that supports people-powered democracy?* At the core of this question is *organizing*, the work underlying building people power for social change through the transformation of individuals and groups into actors (or, to use organizing terminology, to develop leaders) able to effectively pursue shared goals in the public domain [5]. Organizing seeks to develop agentic civic actors connected to a durable and accountable base as a pathway for turning available resources into the power needed to drive sociopolitical change [3, 5, 13, 15, 25].

Our aim is to bring together researchers with interests widely across CSCW who share a commitment to broadening a vision for HCI research that is community-driven and -engaged, justice-oriented, innovative, and values-centered. Organizing is a topic that is relevant to several existing subfields of CSCW, including civic and community technologies [4, 10], healthcare technologies [6], crowdsourcing [22], hybrid and relation work [2], and collective actions [24]. Specifically, this SIG is designed for researchers who recognize the value and limitations in their own subfields to building power for social change.

This SIG is designed as a venue for collective advancement of CSCW research by sparking conversations around concepts and approaches to *power* and *organizing* and facilitating small- and large-group discussions for seeding new potential collaborations and future work. Participants will be introduced to applicable tools and frameworks, as well as have many opportunities to share or workshop their own community-engaged projects or research-practice partnerships. We will discuss questions inherent to civic technologies, especially around innovation and the research-practice gap, and where AI might have generative possibilities for strengthening the work organizers do.

We hope that the conversations, ideas, and potential collaborations generated from this SIG will not only seed innovative and ambitious new research directions for CSCW but also spark a broader conversation about what it means for technology designers and researchers to build systems and advance knowledge as civic duty and democratic service. There is no time more urgent than now for CSCW researchers to join their communities in organizing to protect, reinvigorate, and rebuild resilient democracies.

2 Proposed Structure

The SIG will be structured in four parts. The SIG will begin with the organizers giving a short welcome and introducing the topic of people power, organizing, and organizing technologies.

Next, we will divide the group into pairs and give each pair a worksheet with guided reflection questions. This worksheet will facilitate one-on-one conversations to surface people's interests and the questions, concerns, and curiosities that bring them to the SIG. Reflection questions will prompt participants to discuss questions around the topic of the SIG (e.g., What is the big unanswered question you are facing in your research and/or organizing right now? How do you hope your participation in today's activities and beyond will help you make progress on this question?).

Following the one-on-ones, we will ask participants to get into small groups (3-5 participants, depending on the size of the SIG) and instruct them to go around the group to introduce themselves and surface the range of interests, experiences, and backgrounds.

Following the group introduction, we will begin applying concepts introduced at the beginning of the session on people power and organizing. One of the SIG organizers will briefly present the context from their own work and organizers will lead the group through a brief "power map" activity. Power maps are a key tool used by organizers to assess key decision-makers and power dynamics within a landscape to identify strategies and tactics for social change. Following the power mapping activity in the full group, we will divide into small groups where participants will complete a guided small group activity to reflect on the role and possibilities of technology questions in the context of the presented case. Small groups will be given a template to summarize their takeaways for large group share-out.

During the large group share-out, moderators will help each small group share their discussion insights. The goal of the stage is for all participants to learn about other's groups discussion and create a shared understanding of the open questions in the field. We will also ask moderators to share how many participants in their tables signed up to continue the conversation after the SIG and we will celebrate those who signed up.

After the SIG, organizers will collect the worksheets and follow up with all participants, inviting them to a follow-up meeting. We will also request that participants bring a colleague. The goal is to bring together researchers from different fields (e.g., learning sciences, political science) to continue engaging in both the practice and intellectual development of organizing technologies, through future potential collaborations and special issues.

2.1 Encouraging interaction with the audience

We have designed a number of different interaction opportunities (1-1, small group, large group) to encourage participants to interact with multiple, and different, participants in the workshop. Additionally, we will encourage participants to directly participate in the interactive activities designed to apply frameworks from power analysis and organizing to CSCW contexts. This may look like participants bringing their own cases and contexts to workshop with the group, or having participants conduct the exercise by applying to an example context that we provide from our own experience. We will also lead all participants through large and small group

activities, supported by guided reflection worksheets and written templates to scaffold their brainstorming.

2.2 Ensuring accessibility to all participants

The preparation for an accessible event will begin prior to the conference. As we recruit participants for the SIG, we will also ask participants to fill out a survey with accessibility requests. We will work with the conference organizers, if necessary, to ensure that accessibility needs are met. During the SIG, we will also make sure that participants with varying levels of knowledge and experience with organizing will have a chance to share their thoughts, if they wish to, by having trained moderators to facilitate small group discussions.

3 Organizers' Bios

This SIG will be organized by researchers with backgrounds in human-computer interaction (HCI) and learning sciences with research and practical experience with community organizing in the United States and Europe.

Dr. Kristine J. Lu is an Assistant Professor of Design at Northeastern University and affiliate of the SNF Agora Institute at Johns Hopkins University who researches and designs tools and technologies for people-powered politics. She works with a range of social movement, grassroots organizing, and local government partners in her engaged and community-based participatory action research, most recently in using social computing technologies to build statewide learning infrastructure for movement innovation across the California movement organizing ecosystem.

Dr. Gustavo Umbelino researches and designs equitable collaboration technologies for organizing civic collective actions through outreach, deliberation, group formation, and coaching. He draws on his academic training in computer science, psychology, and design as well as practical experience as a community organizer for participatory budgeting. He is currently a postdoctoral researcher in Centre for Democracy Studies Aarau, affiliated with the University of Zurich.

Dr. Matthew Easterday is an Associate Professor of Learning Sciences at the Northwestern University School of Education and Social Policy. His research focuses on technology for the new civics – producing scientifically supported educational technology to create informed and engaged citizens who can solve the serious policy problems facing our society such as poverty, climate change and militarism.

Morgan Wu is a Ph.D. candidate in the Learning Sciences program at Northwestern University, based in Illinois, USA. Her research centers on community building, deliberation, and participatory democracy, with a particular focus on designing and constructing informal learning environments for citizens. Her work aims to equip individuals with advocacy competence and to actively engage in democratic processes and civic life. Morgan has contributed to projects such as the Participatory Budgeting in Evanston. She is a co-founder and board member of Open Democracy.

4 Technical Requirements

We will require a large, shared display all participants can see (e.g., a projector, large monitor) with HDMI ports, an HDMI cable, and a PA system with at least two microphones.

References

- [1] Tanja Aitamurto and Hélène Landemore. 2016. Crowdsourced Deliberation: The Case of the Law on Off-Road Traffic in Finland: Crowdsourced Deliberation. *Policy & Internet* 8, 2 (June 2016), 174–196. <https://doi.org/10.1002/poi3.115>
- [2] Pernille Bjørn and Lars Rune Christensen. 2011. Relation work: Creating socio-technical connections in global engineering. In *ECSCW 2011: Proceedings of the 12th European Conference on Computer Supported Cooperative Work, 24–28 September 2011, Aarhus Denmark, 2011*. Springer, London, 133–152. https://doi.org/10.1007/978-0-85729-913-0_8
- [3] Marshall Ganz. 2024. *People, Power, Change: Organizing for Democratic Renewal*. Oxford University Press, Oxford, New York.
- [4] Sucheta Ghoshal and Amy Bruckman. 2019. The Role of Social Computing Technologies in Grassroots Movement Building. *ACM Trans. Comput.-Hum. Interact.* 26, 3 (June 2019), 18:1–18:36. <https://doi.org/10.1145/3318140>
- [5] Hahrie Han, Matthew Baggetta, and Jennifer Oser. 2024. Organizing and Democracy: Understanding the Possibilities for Transformative Collective Action. *Annual Review of Political Science* 27, Volume 27, 2024 (July 2024), 245–262. <https://doi.org/10.1146/annurev-polisci-041322-043040>
- [6] Christina N. Harrington, Katya Borgos-Rodriguez, and Anne Marie Piper. 2019. Engaging Low-Income African American Older Adults in Health Discussions through Community-based Design Workshops. In *Proceedings of the 2019 CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems (CHI '19)*, May 02, 2019. Association for Computing Machinery, New York, NY, USA, 1–15. <https://doi.org/10.1145/3290605.3300823>
- [7] Margaret Hughes and Emily S. Lin. 2021. From Alinsky to Zoom: Understanding Relational, Constituency-Based Organizing in 2021. In *Companion Publication of the 2021 Conference on Computer Supported Cooperative Work and Social Computing (CSCW '21 Companion)*, October 2021. Association for Computing Machinery, New York, NY, USA, 335–337. <https://doi.org/10.1145/3462204.3481727>
- [8] Ian G. Johnson, Alistair MacDonald, Jo Briggs, Jennifer Manuel, Karen Salt, Emma Flynn, and John Vines. 2017. Community Conversational: Supporting and Capturing Deliberative Talk in Local Consultation Processes. In *Proceedings of the 2017 CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems (CHI '17)*, May 02, 2017. Association for Computing Machinery, New York, NY, USA, 2320–2333. <https://doi.org/10.1145/3025453.3025559>
- [9] Vera Khovanskaya, Phoebe Sengers, and Lynn Dombrowski. 2020. Bottom-Up Organizing with Tools from On High: Understanding the Data Practices of Labor Organizers. In *Proceedings of the 2020 CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems (CHI '20)*, April 2020. Association for Computing Machinery, New York, NY, USA, 1–13. <https://doi.org/10.1145/3313831.3376185>
- [10] Christopher Le Dantec. 2012. Participation and publics: supporting community engagement. In *Proceedings of the SIGCHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems (CHI '12)*, May 05, 2012. Association for Computing Machinery, New York, NY, USA, 1351–1360. <https://doi.org/10.1145/2207676.2208593>
- [11] Rachel Leingang, Andrew Gumbel, and Melissa Hellmann. 2025. Millions across US turn out for 'No Kings' protests against Donald Trump. *The Guardian*. Retrieved June 18, 2025 from <https://www.theguardian.com/us-news/2025/jun/14/no-kings-protests-trump-military-parade>
- [12] Calvin Alan Liang, Emily Tseng, Akeiyah Dewitt, Yasmine Kotturi, Sucheta Ghoshal, Angela D. R. Smith, Marisol Wong-Villacres, Lauren Wilcox, and Sheena Erete. 2023. Surfacing Structural Barriers to Community-Collaborative Approaches in Human-Computer Interaction. In *Companion Publication of the 2023 Conference on Computer Supported Cooperative Work and Social Computing (CSCW '23 Companion)*, October 2023. Association for Computing Machinery, New York, NY, USA, 542–546. <https://doi.org/10.1145/3584931.3611294>
- [13] Jane F. McAlevey. 2016. *No Shortcuts: Organizing for Power in the New Gilded Age*. Oxford University Press, Oxford, New York.
- [14] Maria Menendez-Blanco and Pernille Bjørn. 2022. Designing Digital Participatory Budgeting Platforms: Urban Biking Activism in Madrid. *Comput. Supported Coop. Work* 31, 4 (December 2022), 567–601. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s10606-022-09443-6>
- [15] Aldon D. Morris. 1986. *Origins of the Civil Rights Movements*. Retrieved June 19, 2025 from <https://www.simonandschuster.com/books/Origins-of-the-Civil-Rights-Movements/Aldon-D-Morris/9780029221303>
- [16] Matti Nelimarkka, Salla-Maaria Laaksonen, and Bryan Semaan. 2018. Social Media Is Polarized, Social Media Is Polarized: Towards a New Design Agenda for Mitigating Polarization. In *Proceedings of the 2018 Designing Interactive Systems Conference (DIS '18)*, June 08, 2018. Association for Computing Machinery, New York, NY, USA, 957–970. <https://doi.org/10.1145/3196709.3196764>
- [17] The International Fact-Checking Network. 2016. An open letter to Mark Zuckerberg from the world's fact-checkers. *Poynter*. Retrieved June 18, 2025 from <https://www.poynter.org/fact-checking/2016/an-open-letter-to-mark-zuckerberg-from-the-worlds-fact-checkers/>
- [18] Nord, Marina, David Altman, Fabio Angiolillo, Tiago Fernandes, Ana Good God, and Staffan I. Lindberg. 2025. *Democracy Report 2025: 25 Years of Autocratization – Democracy Trumped?* University of Gothenburg: V-Dem Institute, Gothenburg,

- Sweden. Retrieved June 17, 2025 from https://www.v-dem.net/documents/61/v-dem-dr_2025_lowres_v2.pdf
- [19] Victoria Palacin, Samantha McDonald, Pablo Aragón, and Matti Nelimarkka. 2024. Configurations of Digital Participatory Budgeting. *ACM Trans. Comput.-Hum. Interact.* 31, 2 (February 2024), 28:1-28:28. <https://doi.org/10.1145/3635144>
- [20] Jorge Saldivar, Florian Daniel, Luca Cernuzzi, and Fabio Casati. 2019. Online Idea Management for Civic Engagement: A Study on the Benefits of Integration with Social Networking. *Trans. Soc. Comput.* 2, 1 (January 2019), 1:1-1:29. <https://doi.org/10.1145/3284982>
- [21] Jorge Saldivar, Cristhian Parra, Marcelo Alcaraz, Rebeca Arteta, and Luca Cernuzzi. 2018. Civic Technology for Social Innovation. *Comput. Supported Coop. Work* 27, 3–6 (December 2018), 1215–1253. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s10606-018-9311-7>
- [22] Niloufar Salehi, Lilly C. Irani, Michael S. Bernstein, Ali Alkhatib, Eva Ogbe, Kristy Milland, and Clickhappier. 2015. We Are Dynamo: Overcoming Stalling and Friction in Collective Action for Crowd Workers. In *Proceedings of the 33rd Annual ACM Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems (CHI '15)*, April 18, 2015. Association for Computing Machinery, New York, NY, USA, 1621–1630. <https://doi.org/10.1145/2702123.2702508>
- [23] Saiph Savage, Andres Monroy-Hernandez, and Tobias Höllerer. 2016. Botivist: Calling Volunteers to Action using Online Bots. In *Proceedings of the 19th ACM Conference on Computer-Supported Cooperative Work & Social Computing (CSCW '16)*, February 27, 2016. Association for Computing Machinery, New York, NY, USA, 813–822. <https://doi.org/10.1145/2818048.2819985>
- [24] Aaron Shaw, Haoqi Zhang, Andrés Monroy-Hernández, Sean Munson, Benjamin Mako Hill, Elizabeth Gerber, Peter Kinnaird, and Patrick Minder. 2014. Computer supported collective action. *interactions* 21, 2 (March 2014), 74–77. <https://doi.org/10.1145/2576875>
- [25] Deva R. Woodly. 2022. *Reckoning: Black Lives Matter and the Democratic Necessity of Social Movements*. Oxford University Press, Oxford, New York.
- [26] The New Yorker. 2025. Representative Ro Khanna on Elon Musk and the Tech Oligarchy. *The New Yorker*. Retrieved June 18, 2025 from <https://www.newyorker.com/podcast/the-new-yorker-radio-hour/representative-ro-khanna-on-elon-musk-and-the-tech-oligarchy>